

Meridian Design System — Reference Guide

A reusable visual language extracted from the Alumni Mentorship Platform. Copy the tokens and patterns below into any new project.

1. Design Thesis

Every choice traces back to one idea: **"wisdom traveling through a network, not a hierarchy."** That's why the layout avoids the sidebar-admin-panel look entirely and why the signature visual is a connected node graph, not a stat card. When you reuse this system elsewhere, start by naming your own one-sentence thesis — it's what stops the palette/type/layout choices from feeling generic.

2. Color Palette

Dark mode is the default; light mode is a full token swap, not just an inverted filter.

Dark (default)

Token	Hex	Use
--ink-950	 #05070c	Deepest shadow / overlay backdrop
--ink-900	 #0a0e18	Page background
--ink-850	 #0d1220	Raised surfaces (modals, nav)
--ink-800	 #121829	Card backgrounds (pre-alpha)
--ink-700	 #1a2236	Borders on raised surfaces
--ink-600	 #262f47	Chart "empty" segments
--ink-500	 #384265	Muted chart fill
--gold-300 → --gold-600	 #e7cb8e →  #a9813f	Primary accent (brass/gold — reads institutional, not techy)
--teal-400/500/600	 #5fd4c2 /  #3fbfad /  #2e9686	Secondary accent — "positive/available" states

Token	Hex	Use
<code>--rose-</code> <code>400/500/600</code>	 <code>#e08b8b</code> /  <code>#d96c6c</code> /  <code>#b34f4f</code>	Muted brick-red for "negative/rejected" states — deliberately not a saturated alarm red
<code>--text-hi</code>	 <code>#f4f1ea</code>	Primary text (warm off-white, not pure white)
<code>--text-mid</code>	 <code>#b9c0d0</code>	Secondary text
<code>--text-low</code>	 <code>#7c86a0</code>	Tertiary/meta text

Light mode overrides

Same variable names, new values — everything downstream (cards, borders, shadows) inherits automatically:

CSS

```
--ink-900: #f5f1e8; /* background becomes warm parchment, not white */
--ink-850: #efe9dc;
--bg-raised: #ffffdf8;
--text-hi: #1c1a14;
--text-mid: #4a4638;
--text-low: #756c56;
--border-soft: rgba(28,26,20,0.08);
```

Why this works as a reusable formula: pick one warm neutral (ink) as your 6–7 step scale, one "brand" accent used sparingly (gold), one "success/positive" accent (teal), one "muted negative" accent (rose that's desaturated, not fire-engine red). Never introduce a second bright accent — the gold is the only color allowed to feel "loud."

3. Typography

CSS

```
--font-display: "Fraunces", Georgia, serif; /* headlines, section titles,
--font-body:    "Inter", -apple-system, sans-serif; /* everything else */
--font-mono:    "IBM Plex Mono", monospace; /* eyebrows, timestamps, data
```

- **Fraunces** is a "wonky," high-contrast serif with optical sizing — it reads premium/editorial rather than corporate. Used only for: hero headline, section titles,

big dashboard numbers, modal titles. Never for body copy or UI chrome.

- **Inter** carries every button, label, paragraph, and form field — a neutral workhorse so the serif stands out.
- **IBM Plex Mono** is the "data" voice: eyebrow labels (uppercase, letter-spaced), timestamps, stat captions. Mono type signals "this is a system value," which is a cheap but effective way to make dashboards feel data-driven.

Type scale used:

- Hero title: `clamp(2.4rem, 5vw, 4.2rem)`, weight 600, line-height 1.05, letter-spacing -0.01em
- Section title: `clamp(1.7rem, 3vw, 2.4rem)`, weight 600
- Big stat number: `52px` Fraunces, weight 600
- Eyebrow (mono): `12.5px`, uppercase, `0.08em` letter-spacing, gold color, preceded by a small glowing dot

Reusable rule: pair one characterful serif (restraint: only on 4-5 elements per page) + one neutral sans for 95% of the UI + one mono for anything that reads as "system data." That 3-face pairing alone makes a page feel designed rather than default.

4. Layout System

No sidebar — floating pill nav instead

CSS

```
.floatnav {  
  position: fixed; top: 18px; left: 50%; transform: translateX(-50%);  
  border-radius: 999px;  
  background: color-mix(in srgb, var(--bg-raised) 68%, transparent);  
  backdrop-filter: blur(20px) saturate(160%);  
  border: 1px solid var(--glass-border);  
}
```

A centered floating capsule nav (Linear/Arc-style) replaces the top bar + sidebar combo. It collapses to a burger + slide-down glass drawer under 720px.

Bento grid for dashboards

Instead of a stat-row + table admin layout, use a 6-column CSS grid where cards span different widths (`span 2`, `span 3`, `span 4`) based on content weight — big number gets 2

columns, activity feed gets 4, etc. This is the single highest-leverage layout trick for making a dashboard feel like a "workspace" rather than a CRUD screen.

CSS

```
.bento { display: grid; grid-template-columns: repeat(6, 1fr); gap: 18px; grid-  
.bento-card span-2 { grid-column: span 3; }
```

Section rhythm

Every content section follows: eyebrow → serif title → one-line gray subtitle → content. This 3-line header pattern is repeated identically across every section so the page reads as one system.

5. Glassmorphism (the actual recipe)

Don't just add `backdrop-filter: blur()` — the combination that reads as "premium glass" rather than "frosted plastic" is:

CSS

```
.glass {  
  background: color-mix(in srgb, var(--bg-raised) 72%, transparent);  
  backdrop-filter: blur(18px) saturate(140%);  
  border: 1px solid var(--glass-border); /* very low-alpha white/black, NOT a v  
}
```

Key details that matter:

- `saturate(140%)` — plain blur looks dull; the saturation boost makes colors behind the glass pop through, which reads as "glass" rather than "smudged."
 - The border is barely-there (`rgba(255, 255, 255, 0.09)` in dark mode) — a strong border kills the glass illusion.
 - Reserve glass for floating/overlaid elements only: nav, modals, toasts, the composer. Regular content cards use a flatter `--bg-card` (a low-alpha white overlay, no blur) so the glass elements stay special.
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One consistent pattern reused for mentor availability, booking status, and toast type:

CSS

```
.status-badge--available { color: teal; } /* good / active / positive */
.status-badge--busy      { color: gold;  } /* neutral / pending / caution */
.status-badge--unavailable { color: rose; } /* blocked / negative */
```

Always: a small dot/icon + label pill with a very low-alpha tinted background (`color-mix(in srgb, [accent] 18%, transparent)`), never a solid-fill badge. Reuse this exact 3-state color mapping (teal/gold/rose) anywhere you need status — it's now a "brand pattern," not an arbitrary choice per feature.

7. Motion Principles

- **Hover lift, not hover glow:** cards do `transform: translateY(-3px to -4px)` + border/background shift on hover — never scale or box-shadow-only glows.
- **Spring easing for anything that "pops":** `cubic-bezier(0.34, 1.56, 0.64, 1)` for modals, FAB menu items, theme toggle icon swap.
- **Standard ease for everything else:** `cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)` (a snappy ease-out) for hovers, page-load fades.
- **One signature animated moment** — the hero's node network uses a slow dash-offset animation (`stroke-dasharray` + `@keyframes dashflow`) plus staggered node-opacity pulses. This is the *one* place with ambient looping motion; everything else animates only in response to interaction.
- **Respect `prefers-reduced-motion`:** collapse all durations to ~0 and disable smooth-scroll globally when it's set.

CSS

```
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {
  *, *::before, *::after { animation-duration: 0.001ms !important; transition-d
}
```

8. Component Shape Language

- **Radius scale:** `--radius-sm: 10px`, `--radius-md: 16px`, `--radius-lg: 24px`, `--radius-`

`pill: 999px`). Buttons, chips, nav, and tabs are always full pill; cards and modals use `lg`; small inputs use `sm`. Never mix an arbitrary radius outside this scale.

- **Shadows:** two-layer shadows only — a tight 1-2px "contact" shadow plus a large soft blurred shadow, e.g. `0 1px 2px rgba(0,0,0,.3), 0 12px 32px -12px rgba(0,0,0,.55)`. A single soft shadow looks flat; the tight+soft combo gives cards physical weight.
 - **Avatars:** initials-based, colored from a fixed 6-color rotation (`GOLD_SET` array), never photos or external image dependencies — makes the whole thing self-contained and consistent.
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9. How to Port This to a New Project

1. Swap the ink scale's hue (keep it a warm or cool neutral, not pure gray) and pick one accent that matches the new subject's world — the accent is doing most of the "identity" work.
2. Keep the 3-typeface rule (characterful serif / neutral sans / mono for data) even if you change the actual fonts.
3. Reuse the bento-grid dashboard pattern any time you'd otherwise reach for a generic stat-row + sidebar.
4. Reuse the glass recipe (blur + saturate + near-invisible border) only for floating/overlaid UI, not for every card.
5. Pick one signature animated element tied to the subject's actual concept (here: a mentorship *network*) rather than a generic gradient blob.
6. Always define the status color mapping once (3 states: positive/neutral/negative) and reuse it everywhere status appears.